

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Ex-aide to be running mate in '26 for Pritzker

Mitchell has government experience, plus life story different from governor

By Olivia Olander, Rick Pearson and Jeremy Gorner
Chicago Tribune

Elevating a former top aide with legislative and executive experience — and a life story different from his own — Gov. JB Pritzker on Tuesday announced Christian Mitchell would be his third term running mate.

“He’s a guy who knows how to get big things done, and I’ve worked with him to get it done, and I’m excited for the people of Illinois to get to know him,” Pritzker said Tuesday in Peoria.

The role on Pritzker’s 2026 ticket opened up with the state’s two-term lieutenant governor, Juliana Stratton, making a bid to succeed retiring U.S. Sen. Dick Durbin. The office could receive more attention as Pritzker looks to keep building his legacy in the state while also raising his national profile ahead of a potential 2028 presidential bid.

“I’m really most excited to keep moving Illinois forward. You’re seeing in Washington quite a bit of chaos,” Mitchell said in an interview Tuesday morning. “The progress we’ve made in Illinois is more important than ever, and is more important to protect now than ever.”

Politically, Mitchell brings to the Pritzker ticket a compelling personal story of being raised by a single mom, with his grandfather, a military veteran, serving to instill strong values of public service, friends and associates said.

At age 38, Mitchell represents a nod to a younger generation for the

Turn to Mitchell, Page 4



Senate Majority Leader John Thune, R-S.D., emerges from the chamber just after passage of the budget reconciliation package of President Donald Trump's signature bill of big tax breaks and spending cuts at the Capitol in Washington on Tuesday. J. SCOTT APPLEWHITE/AP

Senate advances Trump's tax and spending package

After tense weekend, three Republicans vote no with Democrats as Vance breaks tie

By Lisa Mascaro, Mary Clare Jalonick and Matt Brown

Associated Press

WASHINGTON — Senate Republicans hauled President Donald Trump's big tax breaks and spending cuts bill to passage Tuesday by the narrowest of margins, pushing past opposition from Democrats and their own GOP ranks after a turbulent overnight session.

The outcome capped an unusually tense weekend of work

at the Capitol, the president's signature legislative priority teetering on the edge of approval or collapse. In the end that tally was 50-50, with Vice President JD Vance casting the tie-breaking vote.

Three GOP senators — Thom Tillis of North Carolina, Susan Collins of Maine and Rand Paul of Kentucky — joined all Democrats in voting against it.

“In the end we got the job done,” Senate Majority Leader John Thune of South Dakota said afterward.

The difficulty for Republicans, who have the majority in Congress, to wrestle the bill to this point is not expected to let up. The package now goes back to the House, where Speaker Mike Johnson of Louisiana had warned senators not to overhaul what his chamber had already approved. But the Senate did make changes, particularly to Medicaid, risking more problems ahead. House GOP leaders scheduled a Wednesday vote and vowed to send it to Trump by his July Fourth deadline.

It's a pivotal moment for the president and his party, as they have been consumed by the 887-page “One Big Beautiful Bill Act,” which was its formal title before Democrats filed an amendment to strip out the name. Republicans invested their political capital in delivering on their sweep of power in Washington.

Trump acknowledged it's “very complicated stuff” as he departed the White House for Florida.

Turn to Bill, Page 13

Asbestosis patient gets lifesaving transplant

Receives new lungs as EPA reconsiders its ban on asbestos

By Rebecca Johnson
Chicago Tribune

Michael Mihalik had a secret. As he celebrated Christmas with his four children, he thought it was probably his last. So in between the food and presents, he told them elaborate goodbyes in his head.

He was suffering from asbestosis, an occupational lung disease caused by inhaling asbestos fibers. The condition leads to lung tissue scarring and shortness of breath, which Mihalik knew all too well. By December 2023, he needed



Michael Mihalik, a double-lung transplant recipient who was diagnosed with asbestosis, is given a spirometry pre/post test Tuesday to assess how well his new lungs are working by Sardina Aurelia, a registered respiratory therapist/certified pulmonary function technologist, at Loyola Medicine-Oak Brook Terrace. ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

10 liters of supplemental oxygen just to sit — 15 liters for any kind of movement, he said.

“I just gave up on everything. I figured this was my destiny,” said Mihalik, 66, of Kewanna, Indiana. “It’s my time to go home. The Lord wants me. I’ll just go home.”

But then, by chance during that

Christmas trip, he saw an article in a newspaper about a successful lung transplant for an asbestosis patient. He said he bought at least five copies of the newspaper. The information in it led him to doctors at Loyola University

Turn to Transplant, Page 2

STALLED JUSTICE

13 years after charges filed, mom convicted of murder

Case involving toddler's death, lengthy delays highlights slow courts

By Joe Mahr
Chicago Tribune

Thirteen years after she was first charged with killing her toddler, a former Midlothian woman was found guilty of murder this week in a case that highlights just how long the Cook County courts can take to resolve cases.

A jury convicted Marles Blackman, 50, after deliberating more than 10 hours Friday and Monday. She had spent more than nine years in jail awaiting trial — and then another four years on electronic monitoring at home — before the jury trial began June 23. With the jury's verdict, she was taken back into

custody to await sentencing.

Blackman's attorney, Derrick Reese, argued to the jury that Blackman's 2½-year-old child, Lavandis Hudson, died in July 2011 from medical complications that he'd struggled with since birth.

“You’ve got a mother over here who’s been wrongly accused,” Reese said during his closing argument, after walking over to Blackman at the defense table and gently rubbing her shoulders. “She’s been going through hell.”

But prosecutors described a woman who “brutally” beat her child after regaining custody from a foster mother. Prosecutors said that medical experts found no evidence the boy had a seizure, as Blackman initially reported in a call to 911, and that experts had determined the

Turn to Conviction, Page 4

Trump tours ‘Alligator Alcatraz’

President said immigration detention center in Florida could be model for future projects. **Nation & World**

Playful, and yet precise

Avondale's Void is a whimsical Italian American refuge for the weird and wonderful in Chicago. **Food & Health**

Patiently biding his time

Questions for Cubs President Jed Hoyer multiply as the trade deadline nears. **Chicago Sports**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 88 Low 70

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 20

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